Kathua. The haul was seen as a source of relief ahead of the Amarnath Yatra which starts on June 30. But a top police officer says it's just "the tip of the iceberg"—many such consignments have reached the hands of militants. That revelation came during the interrogation of recently arrested 'hybrid militants'—those who lead a normal family life during inactive times. The upsurge in target killings this year—19 murders, including that of Kashmiri Pandits, civic body officials and policemen—is ascribed to such hybrid militants.

Former Indian army chief Gen. M.M. Naravane has flagged another "major cause of concern"—US-made weapons left behind in Afghanistan making their way to Kashmir. Sophisticated handguns, night-vision devices, steel-piercing bullets, M-16 assault rifles, M-4 carbines...these are just some of the arms recovered recently after raids and gunfights. The Analytical Support and Sanctions Monitoring Team of the UN Security Council has written about the ties between the Taliban and Kashmir-focused terror groups in Pakistan like the LeT and Jaish-e-Mohammed.

Cheap and portable, the potential use of sticky bombs by militants is a new threat for the Amarnath pilgrimage

The sticky bomb threat, though, is what worries security forces most. ADGP Singh says his force has adopted measures including "SOPs and intensified vigil to counter the new threat". Patrolling and deployment has been stepped up along highways and arterial roads, where security convoys move.

But the 43-day Amarnath Yatra—resuming this year after a two-year hiatus caused by the pandemic—is creating some nervousness, especially after a militant group warned it "would spill blood". A senior security official says the strategy has been reworked to ensure smooth passage for the half a million-plus pilgrims expected. In a security huddle in Srinagar on June 14, J&K DGP Dilbagh Singh directed special traffic regulations and drones and CCTVs for close surveillance.

The whole shift comes against a background, of course. Defence expert and ex-armyman Pravin Sawhney says, "Things have changed after India crossed the red line by revoking Article 370. China and Pakistan are carefully monitoring the situation in the Valley, and using the frustration on the ground for their own strategic ends." ■

GUJARAT

THE EX-COP WHO LEADS BJP'S CHARGE

By Kiran D. Tare

Never after Narendra Modi has the Gujarat BJP had a political personality of any significance. And frankly, it has never needed one. The sight of a Gujarati saffron icon ensconsed in India's top job has sufficed to confer an endless gift on the state unit. But in a year when the BJP will seek to stamp its dominance on the Gujarat assembly like never before, it needs a micro-manager cut of the same cloth as Modi—even if tailored to a lesser calling. And it has one in state BJP president C.R. Patil. He has become the last word on anything to do with the state unit. The very mention of 'CR' is considered a go-ahead for any decision. As the party gears up to ensure its uninterrupted run in power since 1999 is only further entrenched after assembly polls in December, a lot hinges on the 67-year-old former policeman's organisational skills.

TUSHAR TANKARIYA



IN MISSION MODE
Gujarat BJP chief C.R. Patil at a mass wedding ceremony in Rajkot, May 17

His eyes on an ambitious target of 150 seats out of 181, surpassing the record 149 bagged by the Congress under Madhavsinh Solanki in 1985, Patil embarked on a statewide 'One Day, One District' campaign in April. His idea of forming 'page committees' will likely swell the number of active party workers from 130,000 to 350,000 by August—the idea is to deploy six-man teams for every 30 voters, the number figuring on each page of the voters' list. "Half the campaign" will be done with that task accomplished, claimed Patil. His word carries weight. In the 2021 civic polls, held the year after Patil took over, he made the bold choice of not giving tickets to kith and kin and those who have completed three terms. A phenomenal perfor-

In the 2021 civic polls, Patil boldly chose not to give tickets to those who had completed three terms